

PANEL OF THE DAWN

A STORY-DRIVEN AI-ASSISTED ACTION-ADVENTURE GAME

“You are not defined by the panel you were written into.”

HACKATHON PROJECT PROPOSAL

Cinematic gameplay • Comic-book world • Light-based reality manipulation • AI-assisted development

Genre	Cinematic action-adventure / exploration / puzzle
Platform Target	PC first; scalable to console in future
Engine	O3DE
Core Innovation	Light physically changes and rewrites the comic-book world
Development Approach	AI-assisted design, art, coding, dialogue, audio and testing

1. Project Overview

Panel of the Dawn is a cinematic, story-driven action-adventure game set inside a living comic-book universe called Ink City. The player controls Rex “Flicker” Vance, an ordinary survivor who begins with a tiny spark of light and gradually gains the ability to manipulate the physical rules of the comic itself.

The game combines exploration, combat, environmental puzzles, character-driven storytelling and a visual system in which light is not merely an effect—it is a gameplay tool that can reveal, create, destroy and eventually rewrite reality.

2. Problem / Opportunity

- Many narrative games tell players a story, but fewer make the story’s rules themselves part of the gameplay.
- Players often experience predetermined worlds where the environment and narrative remain separate systems.
- There is an opportunity to create a memorable game where the central theme—freedom from a predetermined role—is directly expressed through mechanics.
- AI-assisted development can help a small team rapidly prototype visuals, code, dialogue, environments and content while keeping the creative direction human-led.

3. Proposed Solution

Panel of the Dawn turns the comic-book metaphor into a playable system. The player starts with a weak spark called Flicker. As Rex grows, light becomes Photon Ink and later a narrative power capable of changing panels, environments and game rules.

- Explore a dark, layered comic universe.
- Fight enemies using light, movement and evolving abilities.
- Solve puzzles by illuminating objects and changing their state.
- Enter memories through discarded or damaged panels.
- Progress from manipulating objects to manipulating the story itself.

4. Story & Narrative

The Hero

Rex “Flicker” Vance is an orphan and survivor from the darkest slums of Ink City. He is not introduced as a chosen one, legendary warrior or destined savior. His only unusual ability is a tiny spark of light.

The Villain

Overlord Eclipse rules the upper tiers and controls the Master Printing Press. He appears to be the ultimate villain, but the truth is more complicated: Eclipse was once the hero of the comic and became obsessed with controlling its story after the creators abandoned the universe.

The Major Twist — Panel 3

Near the climax, Rex discovers the hidden record of his existence:

REX VANCE
ROLE: BACKGROUND CHARACTER
IMPORTANCE: NONE
PURPOSE: TEMPORARY
FATE: DIE
LOCATION: PANEL 3

Rex was never supposed to become the hero. His predetermined fate is to die in Panel 3. Instead of accepting the script, he rejects it.

“Then Panel 3 was wrong.”

The story then evolves from a conventional hero-versus-villain conflict into a struggle against The Great Erasure, a force that begins deleting the entire comic universe. Rex and Eclipse ultimately confront the threat together.

5. Core Gameplay

System	Player Experience
Exploration	Discover districts, hidden panels, memories, NPC stories, secrets and environmental clues.
Combat	Third-person action combat with light-based attacks, dodging, upgrades and enemy weaknesses.
Light Manipulation	Illuminate objects to reveal, activate, transform or destroy them.
Panel Puzzles	Use comic panels as physical spaces, platforms, doors and memory gateways.
Progression	Flicker → Photon Ink → Panel Manipulation → Story Breaker.
Boss Encounters	Bosses alter arenas and rules rather than relying only on large health bars.

6. Ability Progression

- Flicker — a weak spark that provides basic light and survival tools.

- Photon Ink — weaponized illumination, shadow absorption, light platforms and environmental interaction.
- Panel Manipulation — alter objects, open panels, enter memories and reshape parts of the environment.
- Story Breaker — break panel boundaries and manipulate rules that previously governed the world.

7. World Design

Location	Purpose
Ink City Slums	Dark opening zone where Rex learns to survive.
Forgotten Panels	Lost spaces containing memories, secrets and environmental puzzles.
The Abyss	Psychological story chapter where Rex confronts his past.
Upper Tiers	Powerful districts controlled by Eclipse.
Silent Library	Lore location where Rex discovers the truth about Panel 3.
Master Printing Press	Eclipse's domain and the symbolic center of narrative control.
Great Erasure	Reality-breaking final zone where the comic itself begins disappearing.
Beyond the Page	Final space outside the normal rules of the comic.

8. Visual Identity

- 3D cinematic environments with a living comic-book aesthetic.
- Monochrome ink-based world that evolves toward powerful light and color.
- Dynamic comic panels, ink splashes, page transitions, halftone-inspired effects and dramatic framing.
- Visual storytelling: the interface, environment and narrative can intentionally break the fourth wall.
- Contrast between Rex's warm/golden light and Eclipse's dark/purple visual language.

9. AI-Assisted Development

AI is used as a development accelerator rather than as a replacement for creative direction. The team defines the game's vision, validates outputs and integrates the final assets and systems.

Area	AI Role
Game Design	Generate and refine mechanics, quests, level ideas, balancing and technical specifications.
Story	Narrative development, dialogue drafts, lore,

	character arcs and branching ideas.
Visual Development	Concept art, character references, environment references, storyboards and promotional visuals.
3D Pipeline	AI-assisted 3D concept-to-model workflows, followed by optimization and integration.
Programming	AI-assisted Blueprint/C++ generation, debugging, documentation and test-case creation.
Audio	Prototype music, ambience, sound concepts and voice workflows with appropriate rights/licensing.
Testing	Generate test scenarios and edge cases; human playtesting remains essential.

10. Technology Stack

- O3DE — game engine, rendering, gameplay integration and cinematics.
- Blueprints + C++ — gameplay systems and performance-critical features.
- Blender — 3D modeling, cleanup, rigging and asset preparation.
- AI creation tools — concept generation, ideation, coding assistance and content acceleration.
- O3DE cinematic tools — cinematic storytelling.
- Git/Perforce — version control and collaborative development.

11. Development Roadmap

Phase	Deliverable
Phase 1 — Concept	Lock story, core mechanic, art direction and game design document.
Phase 2 — Prototype	Rex movement, basic combat, Flicker, light interaction and one puzzle.
Phase 3 — Vertical Slice	A polished playable sequence from Ink City through Eclipse and the Photon Ink awakening.
Phase 4 — Production	Build chapters, characters, environments, enemies, bosses, quests and progression.
Phase 5 — Alpha	Complete beginning-to-end playable campaign and fix major blockers.
Phase 6 — Beta	Playtesting, accessibility, optimization and bug fixing.
Phase 7 — Release	Final polish, trailer, store materials and launch build.

12. Hackathon MVP / Demo Scope

The hackathon version should prove the unique idea rather than attempt the entire commercial game.

1. Opening in Ink City with a short playable exploration section.

2. Rex movement and basic combat.
3. Flicker light ability.
4. One enemy whose weakness is revealed by light.
5. One environmental puzzle where light changes the level.
6. Short Eclipse encounter demonstrating the power gap.
7. Abyss sequence and Photon Ink awakening.
8. Final visual reveal that introduces the Panel 3 mystery.

This vertical slice demonstrates the project's core loop, visual identity, narrative hook and technical innovation within a realistic hackathon scope.

13. What Makes the Project Stand Out

- Story and gameplay are mechanically connected: the theme of rewriting destiny becomes a playable system.
- Light is a core interaction mechanic, not just a visual effect.
- The game changes its own rules as Rex's understanding of the story changes.
- The Panel 3 twist reframes the player's understanding of the protagonist.
- AI-assisted production enables rapid iteration of a visually ambitious concept.
- The concept is expandable into a full campaign, DLC and future stories without requiring the hackathon build to contain everything.

14. Player Experience & Emotional Journey

The intended emotional progression is: Curiosity → Fear → Helplessness → Attachment → Discovery → Empowerment → Shock → Understanding → Freedom → Inspiration.

**The goal is for players to finish the game thinking:
“If Rex can rewrite his story, maybe I can rewrite mine too.”**

15. Impact & Vision

Panel of the Dawn aims to show that a person's starting circumstances, labels or assigned role do not have to determine their future. The game communicates this message through the player's actions, not only through dialogue.

- Short-term: deliver a compelling hackathon prototype with a clear innovation.
- Medium-term: expand the vertical slice into a complete narrative game.
- Long-term: establish a distinctive original game universe that can support sequels and new stories.

16. One-Minute Judge Pitch

Panel of the Dawn is a cinematic action-adventure game set inside a living comic-book universe. You play Rex “Flicker” Vance, an ordinary survivor whose only power is a tiny spark of light. As the player explores Ink City, light becomes a gameplay system: it reveals secrets, exposes weaknesses, creates platforms and eventually rewrites reality. The central twist is that Rex was never written to be a hero—he was a background character destined to die in Panel 3. When Rex rejects that fate, the game itself begins to break its rules. The final threat, The Great Erasure, is deleting the entire universe, forcing Rex and Eclipse—the former hero turned ruler—to confront the fate of their world together. Our project combines narrative innovation, gameplay-mechanic integration, strong visual identity and AI-assisted development in one scalable game concept.

17. Final Project Statement

PANEL OF THE DAWN

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